THE CHIMERA OF SEX

FOR SEX DESIRE TO TRANSLATE INTO SEX DEMAND, SEXUAL AWKWARDNESS HAS TO BE NAVIGATED FIRST

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IF

WE WERE TO DESCRIBE THE SEXUAL ECONOMY IN THE LANGUAGE OF ECONOMICS, then the results of the INDIA TODAY-MDRA nationwide sex survey suggest high desire, but not high demand. A majority of those surveyed, both men and women, reported needing more sex. But unlike some other kinds of satisfiable needs, sexual ones depend in part upon other people. And the results tell us that the respondents might be more comfortable opening up on the survey questionnaire than they are with their partners. The survey results show high sexual self-knowledge and sex desire, but they also point to a lag in the willingness to be sexually vulnerable with, and reliant upon, another person in a sexual partnership.

The variables of vulnerability and dependency complicate the overall sex survey results. These variables make the sexual economy unique; they correspond to what might translate as cost or price in the language of material economics, where desire is only considered demand when it is backed up by a willingness to pay. In the sexual economy, willingness to pay means, among other things, being willing to bear the uncertainties of desire within a sexual relationship.

Here, the gender gap presses. Women are more reluctant than men to discuss their sexual needs with their partners: they imagine their partners would not